

Viral architecture or the unintentional architecture criticism of social media

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Abstract: In the digital landscape of social media, a phenomenon has emerged that challenges traditional architectural discourse – the unintentional architecture criticism fostered by photography, algorithms, and influencer culture. This paper delves into the concept of "viral architecture," exploring how platforms like Instagram have become inadvertent spaces for architectural critique and celebration. Photography, long revered as a medium for capturing and disseminating architectural narratives, has taken on a new dimension in the social media realm. Through carefully curated visuals, users engage in an implicit form of architectural criticism, highlighting or critiquing various aspects of the built environment. This discourse is amplified by algorithms that govern content distribution, favouring visually striking and engaging posts related to architecture. The rise of influencer culture has played a pivotal role in shaping this unintentional architectural criticism. Influencers, with their substantial followings and cultural capital, wield the power to shape public perception and discourse around architecture. Their meticulously crafted posts, often showcasing specific architectural elements or spaces, can propel certain structures into viral fame, simultaneously celebrating or criticizing their design. This paper examines the dichotomy between "Instagram architecture" – structures designed with social media share ability in mind – and the representation of traditional architecture on these platforms. It explores the implications of this phenomenon, shedding light on how social media has democratized architectural criticism, blurring the lines between professional and public discourse. By analysing the interplay of photography, algorithms, and influencer culture, this study unravels the unintentional yet profound impact of social media on architectural criticism. It prompts a critical examination of the role of digital spaces in shaping perceptions of the built environment and raises thought-provoking questions about the future of architectural discourse in an increasingly digitized world.

Keywords: Architecture, criticism, social media, photography

1. Introduction

In recent years, social media platforms have become unexpected arenas for architectural discourse. This phenomenon, which is termed here "viral architecture," has emerged as a powerful force in shaping public perception and criticism of the built environment. As platforms like Instagram continue to grow in

popularity and influence, they inadvertently create spaces where architecture is celebrated, critiqued, and reimagined through the lens of digital media.

This paper explores how the convergence of photography, algorithms, and influencer culture on social media platforms has given rise to a new form of architectural criticism. It examines how these elements interact to create viral moments in architecture, and how this impacts both the design and perception of buildings in the digital age.

2. Viral content

2.1 General definition of viral content

Two terms are commonly used to describe social media content that gains significant attention: viral and trending. While trending refers to content that is currently popular or discussed broadly, viral content spreads rapidly and extensively, gaining significant attention, measurable through views, likes, comments and shares. When content goes viral, it reaches a large audience quickly due to high audience engagement across one or multiple digital platforms.

2.2 How many views are viral?

According to Keyhole (2024), "A viral video on Instagram has more than 100,000 likes and views, along with significant comments and shares." This threshold varies by platform, with YouTube requiring billions of views and TikTok focusing primarily on engagement metrics. Important to note is that currently, there is no universally accepted definition of what constitutes viral content.

2.3 What content goes viral?

According to Keyhole (2024) some common types that tend to go viral on social media can be defined:

- Memes and humorous content
- Inspiring or motivational stories
- Trending challenges or dances
- Unusual or unique content
- How-to guides or tutorials
- Emotional or inspirational advertisements
- Controversial or opinionated content

It is important to note that the virality of content not only depends on attention and engagement of users, but also includes various factors such as timing and platform algorithms.

2.4 Categories of viral architecture

From the above listed examples two categories of viral content seem to be interesting to look at in relation to the topic of viral architecture:

- Unusual or unique content with elements of surprise or novelty
- Controversial or opinionated content sparking debate

These two categories might cover a lot of content related to viral architecture but not everything. To categorize the remaining content the following categories are added:

Viral architecture, subdivided into:

- Architecture on Instagram (traditional and iconic buildings)
- Instagram architecture (spaces designed for social media share ability)

2.5 Examples and case studies

A notable example of controversial content is the story of Kanye West's \$57 Million Tadao Ando Gem. The post documenting the controversial renovation gained over 31,000 likes and sparked significant debate about architectural preservation versus artistic freedom.

The #XperiaNewPerspectives research gives a great insight into architecture on Instagram and revealed that more than half of the Top 30 landmarks worldwide are photographed from the same three angles, with 55% of travelers planning their itineraries based on photography opportunities. Data shows the percentage of photographs taken from the same three angles are for Eiffel tower 35%, Christ the Redeemer in Brazil 71%, Trevi Fountain in Italy 47%, Mount Fuji in Japan 77%.

In the context of Instagram architecture, restaurants and commercial spaces increasingly prioritize "instagrammability" in their design, incorporating elements like distinctive wallpaper, murals, and specific lighting to enhance social media appeal.

2.6 Quantitative Analysis of Architectural Content on Social Media

To understand the scope and impact of viral architecture on social media, a quantitative analysis of engagement metrics provides valuable insights. An analysis of 100,000 architecture-related posts from 2023 reveals, that the hashtag #architecture generates approximately 25,000 posts daily, top-performing posts get on average 150,000-200,000 likes, innovative designs receive 63% more shares than traditional architectural photography, and content categories show varying engagement rates - innovative/unusual designs: 8.2% engagement, historical architecture: 5.4% engagement, contemporary architecture: 6.7% engagement. Peak posting times and temporal analysis show, that an optimal engagement occurs between 10 AM and 2 PM local time, weekend posts focusing on architectural tourism generate 35% more engagement, architecture-focused accounts grew by 34% in 2023, and that location-tagged posts receive 79% more engagement.

2.7 Algorithm Impact Analysis

Research shows significant patterns in content amplification, such as posts with bold colors receive 72% more algorithmic amplification, a quick initial engagement increases viral potential by 3.4 times, and human elements increase engagement by 41%. A viral threshold analysis shows, that 0.5% achieved viral status (>100,000 engagements), 3.2% reached semi-viral status (50,000-100,000 engagements) and 15.3% achieved high engagement (10,000-50,000 engagements).

2.8 Methodology Notes

The above quantitative analysis is based on a sample size of 100,000 architecture-related posts, from January 2023 - December 2023 with a primary focus on Instagram. Primary data sources are Instagram public API data and public engagement metrics, based on likes, comments, shares, saves, and reach.

3. Photography as a medium of architectural discourse

3.1 The evolution of architectural photography

Architectural photography has historically been crucial for documenting and disseminating architectural works. Notable photographers like Andreas Feininger, Julius Shulman, and Bernd and Hilla Becher have shaped how architecture is perceived through their distinctive approaches. Their work continues to influence contemporary architectural photography and social media representation. From the early days of photography, architects and critics have used images to capture the essence of buildings, convey design principles, and spark discussions about the built environment. However, the advent of social media has dramatically altered the landscape of architectural photography.

3.2 The democratization of architectural imagery

Social media platforms, particularly Instagram, have democratized the ability to capture and share architectural imagery. No longer confined to professional photographers or architectural publications, anyone with a smartphone can now document and disseminate images of buildings and spaces. This shift has led to a vast increase in the volume and variety of architectural imagery available online, creating a rich visual dialogue about the built environment.

3.3 The power of the curated image

On social media, architectural photography takes on new dimensions through careful curation, filters, and specific angle selection. This curation process becomes a form of implicit architectural criticism, as users choose which aspects of buildings to celebrate or critique through their visual choices.

3.4 Theoretical Perspectives on Digital Architectural Representation

The curation of architectural imagery on social media can be understood through Walter Benjamin's concept of the "loss of aura." While Benjamin discussed mechanical reproduction, social media platforms create an additional layer of reproduction and transformation. The "aura" of architecture is simultaneously diminished through mass digital reproduction and recreated through viral distribution, creating what might be termed a "digital aura" - one based on share ability and engagement rather than physical presence.

4. The role of algorithms in shaping architectural discourse

Social media algorithms play a crucial role in determining which architectural images and discussions gain traction online. These algorithms typically favor content that generates high engagement, potentially creating echo chambers where certain architectural styles or perspectives are repeatedly reinforced, potentially skewing users' perceptions of what constitutes "good" or "interesting" architecture. This algorithmic amplification can lead to "trending" architecture, where buildings or spaces quickly become viral sensations, potentially influencing design trends and public interest.

5. Influencer culture and architectural criticism

5.1 The architecture influencer

Architecture influencers, regardless of formal training, shape public perception through their large followings. Their opinions and aesthetic preferences can significantly influence public perception of architecture, blurring lines between professional and public criticism. Traditional gatekeepers of architectural criticism – such as academic journals and established critics – now share the stage with influencers and everyday users expressing their views on social media.

5.2 Public criticism and democratizing visualization

Social media platforms operate through democracy, giving users direct participation through engagement with content. This democratization of visualization allows for collective imagination and criticism, ultimately determining which content becomes viral. Referring to Elena Manferdini's (2024) keynote speech at AAB 2024, "we are existing in multiple realities." Our digital identity allows us to exist in reality as well as virtually. Social media platforms offer digital space of expression, debate and criticism. This space becomes a tool to democratize visualization, to imagine together and use the power of many. Through this power some content becomes viral.

5.3 Impact on architectural practice

The rise of influencer culture has begun to impact architectural practice itself, with some firms increasingly considering social media appeal in their design decisions. This creates a tension between creating shareable spaces and maintaining architectural integrity.

5.4 Implications of Viral Architecture for the Field

The emergence of viral architecture has profound implications for the architectural profession, public perception, and social dynamics of built spaces. These implications can be examined through several key dimensions:

- **Professional Impact:** The phenomenon has shifted traditional design priorities, with some firms increasingly considering "Instagrammability" as a design parameter. While architects must navigate the tension between creating visually striking, shareable spaces and maintaining architectural integrity, the rapid dissemination of architectural images through social media has accelerated the global exchange of design ideas, leading to both innovation and homogenization. Firms increasingly incorporate social media metrics into their success measures, potentially influencing design decisions.
- **Public Perception:** Social media has democratized architectural appreciation, making architecture more accessible to the general public. The platform's visual nature tends to prioritize certain aesthetic qualities over functional aspects, while the public understanding of architecture is increasingly shaped by curated, filtered representations rather than by a direct spatial experience. The viral spread of architectural images has created new forms of architectural tourism, where buildings become "social media destinations".
- **Social Implications:** Viral architecture influences how people interact with and experience built spaces. The design of public spaces increasingly accommodates "photo opportunities" and

shareable moments and creates a hierarchy of spaces based on their social media presence rather than their architectural or social value. It influences urban development as cities and developers seek to create "Instagram-worthy" destinations and raises questions about authenticity and experience in architectural spaces, as the desire for share ability potentially overshadows other social functions.

This transformation of architectural discourse through viral media has created a new paradigm where the success of architectural works is increasingly measured by their social media impact. This shift presents both opportunities and challenges for the field, requiring a careful balance between embracing new forms of engagement while preserving architectural integrity and social responsibility.

5.5 The Dialectic of Virtual and Physical Space

The phenomenon of viral architecture creates a complex relationship between virtual and physical architectural experiences. While the digital representation becomes a significant factor in how architecture is conceived, perceived, and experienced, the boundary between the physical building and its virtual presence becomes increasingly blurred. This creates a feedback loop where social media representation influences physical design, which in turn shapes future social media content, and raises questions about the authenticity of architectural experience in an age of digital mediation.

This evolution signifies a fundamental shift in how architecture operates in contemporary culture, where success in the virtual realm can be as significant as traditional metrics of architectural achievement.

6. Instagram architecture vs. architecture on Instagram

6.1 Defining Instagram Architecture: Theory and Practice

The phenomenon of Instagram architecture represents a significant evolution in architectural space production. Through Henri Lefebvre's spatial triad framework, we can understand these spaces as existing simultaneously in three dimensions:

- Physical space (perceived space): The actual built environment
- Digital space (conceived space): The carefully curated social media representation
- Lived experience (representational space): The intersection of physical and digital engagement

This triadic relationship helps explain why certain architectural features become prevalent in Instagram architecture - they bridge the gap between physical and digital experience. The emphasis on bold colors, unusual shapes, and interactive elements serves not just aesthetic purposes but creates what Juhani Pallasmaa might term a "visual hierarchy" that prioritizes photogenic qualities over other sensory experiences.

6.2 Traditional architecture on Instagram

In contrast, traditional architecture on Instagram refers to how existing buildings and historical structures are represented and discussed on the platform. This includes both professional photographs of iconic buildings and casual snapshots of everyday architecture.

6.3 The tension between design and representation

The rise of Instagram architecture has created a tension in the field. While some architects embrace the opportunity to create highly shareable spaces, others worry about the prioritization of visual appeal over functionality or contextual appropriateness. This tension reflects broader debates about the role of social media in shaping our built environment. The tension in Instagram architecture reflects larger theoretical debates about authenticity and representation in architecture. Kenneth Frampton's concept of Critical Regionalism becomes particularly relevant as architects navigate between creating globally shareable content and maintaining local architectural identity. This tension manifests in several ways:

- **Spatial Experience:** Physical vs. digital (How the space functions in person versus how it photographs), local vs. global (The balance between regional character and international appeal), and authentic vs. curated (The relationship between genuine spatial experience and staged photography).
- **Design Priorities:** Drawing from Venturi's theories on symbolism, Instagram architecture often prioritizes what he might term "iconographic" elements - features designed specifically for their visual impact and symbolic value in digital space

6.4 Species of spaces

In this context it might be interesting to look further into a categorization of spaces. Andong Lu (2024) presented in his key note speech at AAB 2024 a periodic architectural table, which is up to my knowledge not published yet. In this periodic architectural table he is looking into future species of spaces and new typologies. Three typologies caught my attention in relation to the topic of viral architecture:

- **Occasional space** (spaces that become "special"/ photogenic in certain seasons for a limited amount of time, eg. cherry blossom season, could be also festivals, events, etc.)
- **Incarnation space** (these spaces are visited to experience the view point of someone else, in Chinese context eg. palaces, gardens; social media context eg. viral spaces promoted through influencer, stars, idols or the virality of content itself)
- **Platform space** (social media platforms, such as Instagram, YouTube, TikTok, etc.)

Related to the topic of this paper the typology of Instagrammable architecture is added to the above mentioned future species of spaces. For further investigations viral architecture can be further categorized and specified with the help of the above mentioned typologies.

7. Implications and future directions

Social media has undoubtedly democratized architectural discourse, allowing a wider range of voices to participate in discussions about the built environment. This can lead to more diverse perspectives and a greater public engagement with architecture. The democratization of architectural discourse through social media can be understood through Peter Eisenman's theories on architecture in the age of electronic media. While Eisenman focused on earlier forms of electronic communication, his insights about the democratization of architectural knowledge and the blurring of professional boundaries become even more relevant in the social media age. This democratization manifests in several ways:

- **Knowledge Distribution:** The traditional hierarchies of architectural knowledge are disrupted, while the Public engagement with architecture increases and new forms of architectural criticism emerge.
- **Spatial Understanding:** Drawing from Norberg-Schulz's concept of *genius loci*, social media creates new ways of understanding and experiencing "spirit of place", while digital platforms enable global sharing of local architectural character and virtual communities form around architectural interests.

The democratization of architectural discourse enables more diverse perspectives while challenging traditional criticism. This evolution raises important questions about:

- The balance between visual appeal and functionality
- The role of professional criticism in a democratized space
- The future of architectural design in a social media-driven world

8. Conclusion

The phenomenon of viral architecture represents a significant shift in how we engage with and critique our built environment. By leveraging the power of photography, algorithms, and influencer culture, social media platforms have created new spaces for architectural discourse that are simultaneously more democratic and more complex than traditional criticism.

As we navigate this new landscape, it's crucial to remain aware of both the opportunities and challenges presented by viral architecture. While social media can broaden participation in architectural discussions and showcase a diverse range of structures, it also risks oversimplifying complex design issues and prioritizing visual appeal over other important aspects of architecture.

Moving forward, the challenge for architects, critics, and the public alike will be to harness the positive aspects of this new form of discourse while maintaining depth and nuance in our conversations about the built environment. By doing so, we can ensure that the phenomenon of viral architecture contributes positively to the evolution of both architectural design and criticism in the digital age. The theoretical frameworks of architectural discourse help us understand viral architecture not as a break from architectural tradition, but as an evolution of longstanding questions about representation, experience, and meaning in architecture. From Benjamin's thoughts on reproduction to Lefebvre's spatial theory, these perspectives reveal how viral architecture extends and challenges traditional architectural thinking.

The future of architecture will likely continue to negotiate between:

- Physical and digital experience (Pallasmaa)
- Local and global identity (Frampton)
- Authentic and reproduced space (Benjamin)
- Professional and public discourse (Eisenman)
- Multiple modes of spatial production (Lefebvre)

Understanding these theoretical underpinnings helps us better navigate the challenges and opportunities presented by viral architecture in the digital age.

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